“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 8

The Fault-finding of Rāmacandra Purī

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I worship Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, who, out of fear of Rāmacandra Purī, reduced His own meals to less than the ordinary measure of food.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya, the descent of the ocean of mercy, whose feet Brahmā, Śiva and the other gods worship!

3 Glory, glory to all the devotees headed by Śrīvāsa, for whom the Lord, Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, is the treasure of their lives!

4 In this way Gauracandra enjoyed His pastimes in Nīlācala with His own devotees, in the waves of love for Kṛṣṇa.

5 At that time Rāmacandra Purī Gosāñi came and met Paramānanda Purī and the Lord.

6 Paramānanda Purī paid homage at his feet, and Purī Gosāñi embraced him firmly.

7 Mahāprabhu offered him prostrate obeisance; he embraced the Lord and remembered Kṛṣṇa.

8 For some time the three of them spoke together about the Lord. Then Jagadānanda Paṇḍita invited him for a meal.

9 Jagadānanda brought Jagannātha's prasāda for the meal, and Rāmacandra Purī ate as much as he liked, only to find fault afterwards.

10 When he had eaten, the Purī said, "Listen, Jagadānanda: you eat the prasāda that remains."

11 Insisting, he seated Jagadānanda and fed him, and he himself insistently served the food.

12 Insisting again and again, he fed him; and when Jagadānanda had rinsed his mouth, he began to find fault:

13 "I had heard that Caitanya's followers eat a great deal. That report is true: now I have seen it with my own eyes.

14 Feeding a sannyāsī so much, they ruin his dharma; and though they are renunciants, they eat so much that they have not even a semblance of renunciation!"

15 This was his nature: first he would insist on feeding someone a great deal, and afterwards he would find fault with him.

16 Formerly, when Mādhavendra Purī was departing from this world, Rāmacandra Purī came to him.

17 Purī Gosāñi was chanting the name of Kṛṣṇa, and weeping, "I have not attained Mathurā!"

18 Then Rāmacandra Purī instructed him. Though a disciple, he spoke to his guru without fear:

19 "You are full; remember the bliss of Brahman. You are a knower of Brahman — why do you weep?"

20 Hearing this, Mādhavendra Purī grew angry. “Away, away, you sinner!” he cried, and rebuked him.

21 “I have not attained Kṛṣṇa’s mercy, I have not attained Mathurā. I am leaving this world in my own grief, and this one has come to add burning pain!

22 Never show me your face again; go wherever you like! If I leave this world while looking at you, I shall come to an evil end.

23 I am leaving this world in my own grief, not having attained Kṛṣṇa, and this wretched fool teaches me about Brahman!”

24 Śrī Mādhavendrapāda thus disregarded him, and through that offense worldly desires (*vāsanā*) were born in Rāmacandra Purī.

25 He became a dry knower of Brahman, without any relationship with Kṛṣṇa. He found fault with everyone and clung stubbornly to fault-finding.

26 Īśvara Purī, however, served Śrīpāda Mādhavendra Purī, cleaning away his stool and urine with his own hands.

27 He constantly helped him remember the name of Kṛṣṇa, and at every moment let him hear Kṛṣṇa’s name and Kṛṣṇa’s pastimes.

28 Pleased with him, Purī Gosāñi embraced him and gave him a blessing: “May you have the treasure of love for Kṛṣṇa!”

29 From then on Īśvara Purī was an ocean of love, while Rāmacandra Purī became a fault-finder of everyone.

30 The two of them are witnesses of a great soul’s mercy and punishment; through these two he taught the people of the world.

31 Having given the gift of love, Mādhavendra, the guru of the world, recited this verse and departed from this world:

32 “O Lord, melting with compassion for the wretched! O Lord of Mathurā, when shall I see You? My heart, stricken at not seeing You, has lost all rest. O Beloved, what am I to do?”

33 This verse teaches love for Kṛṣṇa: the special feeling (*bhāva-viśeṣa*) of a devotee in separation from Kṛṣṇa.

34 He planted the sprout of love on the earth and departed. Śrī Caitanya Ṭhākura is the tree that grew from that sprout of love.

35 In this context I have told of Purī Gosāñi’s departure from this world. Whoever hears of it is greatly fortunate.

36 So Rāmacandra Purī stayed on in Nīlācala. Being a renunciant by nature, he stayed now in one place, now in another.

37 He took his meals uninvited, with no fixed rule, and he kept account of how others took their meals.

38 To invite the Lord for a meal cost four paṇas of cowries, for sometimes Kāśīśvara and Govinda ate as well — three persons.

39 Every day the Lord took His meal at one place or another. If someone brought money for it, the amount was fixed at four paṇas.

40 Rāmacandra Purī inquired into everything about the Lord: where He stayed, His ways, His meals, His sleep and His going out.

41 He could not touch any of the Lord’s virtues. He went about seeking faults, but found no fault anywhere.

42 “He is a sannyāsī, yet He eats sweets! With such enjoyment, how can there be control of the senses?”

43 Finding this fault, he spoke of it before everyone; and yet he came every day to see the Lord.

44 Regarding him as a guru, the Lord showed him reverence and honor, but he went about looking for faults — that was his occupation.

45 The Lord knew all the fault-finding he did, yet He still treated him with great respect and reverence.

46 One morning he came to the Lord’s house. Seeing ants there, he made a remark:

47 “Last night there was sugarcane molasses here; that is why the ants are crawling about. Alas! Such is the craving of the senses in renounced sannyāsīs!” Saying this, he got up and left.

48 The Lord had heard of his fault-finding through others; now He heard the invented blame with His own ears.

49 Ants naturally wander about everywhere, yet he raised an argument from it and attached a fault to the Lord.

50 Hearing this, the Lord felt embarrassment and fear in His mind. He called Govinda and spoke to him:

51 “From today this is the rule for My meals: a quarter-pot of the rice offered on Jagannātha’s altar (*piṇḍā-bhoga*), and vegetables worth five gaṇḍās.

52 Take nothing more than this. If you bring more, you will not see Me here again."

53 Govinda told all the Vaiṣṇavas this news. Hearing it, they felt as if a thunderbolt had struck their heads.

54 Everyone reproached Rāmacandra Purī: "This sinner has come here and taken the life of us all!"

55–56 That day a brāhmaṇa invited the Lord. Govinda accepted only a quarter-pot of rice and vegetables worth five gaṇḍās, and the brāhmaṇa struck his head and cried out in grief.

57 The Lord ate half of that rice and vegetables, and whatever remained Govinda received.

58 The Lord ate half a meal and Govinda half a meal, and then all the devotees gave up eating.

59 The Lord ordered Govinda and Kāśīśvara, "You two beg elsewhere and fill your stomachs."

60 Some days passed in this great grief. Hearing of it, Rāmacandra Purī came to the Lord.

61 The Lord bowed down and paid homage at his feet, and the Purī, smiling, spoke to the Lord:

62 "A sannyāsī's dharma is not to gratify the senses. He just fills his stomach somehow or other.

63 I see that You have grown thin, and I hear You eat only half Your meals. This dry renunciation is not a sannyāsī's dharma.

64 He fills his stomach as much as is fitting and does not enjoy sense objects. Then the sannyāsī's *jñāna-yoga* is perfected.

65 'O Arjuna, there is no yoga for one who eats too much, nor for one who does not eat at all, nor for one given to too much sleep, nor for one who stays awake too long.' (Bhagavad-gītā, 6.16)

66 'For one who is regulated in eating and recreation, regulated in his efforts at work, and regulated in sleep and waking, yoga becomes the destroyer of all sorrow.'" (Bhagavad-gītā, 6.17)

67 The Lord said, "I am an ignorant boy, your disciple. That you instruct Me is My good fortune."

68 Hearing this, Rāmacandra Purī got up and left. The Gosāñi heard that the devotees were eating only half their meals.

69 On another day Paramānanda Purī, with the devotees, humbly and courteously submitted to the Lord:

70 "Rāmacandra Purī has the nature of a fault-finder. What will be gained by giving up food at his word?

71 It is the Purī's nature to make people eat as much as they like; whoever does not eat, he feeds with great effort.

72 Having fed him, he then finds fault with him: 'You eat so much food — how much wealth do you have?

73 By feeding a sannyāsī so much, you ruin his dharma! So I know that you have not the slightest semblance of it.'

74 How each person behaves and how each one eats — he is always inquiring into this.

75 The two things that the scriptures forbid are what he does constantly.

76 ‘One should neither praise nor blame the nature and actions of others, seeing the universe as one in nature, together with prakṛti and the puruṣa.’ (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.28.1)

77 Of the two, he gives up the earlier injunction — praise — and practices the later one — blame — knowing that the later one is ‘stronger’.

78 ‘Between an earlier and a later injunction, the later injunction is stronger.’ (a maxim of Nyāya)

79 Where there are a hundred virtues, he does not accept them; among the virtues he deceitfully imputes faults.

80 It is not fitting even to speak of his nature. Still I tell You something of it, for it pains us to the heart.

81 Why do You give up food at his word? Accept invitations as before and heed the request of us all.”

82 The Lord said, “Why are you all angry with the Purī? He speaks the natural dharma of a sannyāsī. What fault is there in him?

83 For a renunciant to be greedy of the tongue is very improper. A renunciant’s dharma is to eat only as much food as keeps him alive.”

84 Then all of them together entreated the Lord earnestly, and at everyone’s insistence the Lord agreed to take half of His former measure.

85 To invite the Lord now cost two paṇas of cowries. Sometimes two persons ate, sometimes three.

86 If a brāhmaṇa whose cooked food could not be accepted invited the Lord, two paṇas of cowries were needed to buy prasāda.

87 If a brāhmaṇa whose cooked food could be accepted invited Him, he would bring some prasāda and cook some at home.

88 When Paṇḍita Gosāñi, Bhagavān Ācārya or Sārvabhauma invited Him on the day of their invitation,

89 the Lord ate according to their wishes. There the Lord had no independence: it was as they wished.

90 The Lord descended to give happiness to His devotees, and He acted as was fitting in each place and situation.

91 Sometimes He followed worldly ways, like an ordinary person; sometimes, being independent, He displayed His divine majesty (*aiśvarya*).

92 Sometimes He was almost like a servant of Rāmacandra Purī; sometimes He paid him no regard and looked on him as a straw.

93 The Lord’s divine conduct is beyond the reach of the intellect. Whatever He does at any time is all enchanting.

94 In this way Rāmacandra Purī stayed some days in Nīlācala and then left on pilgrimage.

95 When he had gone, the Lord’s associates were delighted, as if a stone had suddenly fallen from their heads.

96 Freely the Lord again accepted invitations and freely He sang kīrtana and danced; freely everyone again ate prasāda.

97 When the guru disregards someone, such is the result: gradually he comes to offend even the Lord.

98 Although the Lord, regarding him as a guru, did not take offense at his faults, through their fruit He taught the people.

99 Śrī Caitanya's conduct is like a flood of nectar; when heard, it is sweet to the ears and to the mind.

100 I write of Śrī Caitanya's conduct: hear it with undivided attention, and you will easily attain love for the feet of Śrī Kṛṣṇa.

101 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.